



△ MEANDERING WATERWAY

The lower Mississippi River and its tributaries are slow-moving waterways. They wind through a gently contoured landscape that includes lowland forest habitats, as shown here, and open floodplains.

◁ BIRD'S FOOT DELTA

Also known as a bird's foot delta, due to its shape, the Mississippi River Delta deposits more than 606 million tons (550 million tonnes) of nutrient-rich sediment into the Gulf of Mexico each year, leading to the formation of algal blooms.

The Mississippi-Missouri

A vast river system that extends over much of North America, from the Rocky Mountains in the west to the Appalachians in the east



The Mississippi-Missouri river system is the largest watershed in North America, draining more than 40 percent of the contiguous U.S. (all of the country except for Alaska and Hawaii). The Mississippi River's source is Lake Itasca in northern Minnesota, which it leaves as a stream just 10 ft (3m) wide. The Mississippi's western tributaries, including those of the Missouri, drain the Great Plains, while those to the east drain the Appalachian Plateau.

Great River

In combination, the Mississippi-Missouri stretches 3,710 miles (5,970 km), making it the fourth longest river in the world after the Nile, Amazon, and Yangtze. Also known as the Big Muddy, the silt-laden Missouri discharges into the clearer Mississippi just north of St Louis in Missouri. However, it is only after its confluence with the Ohio River—the Mississippi's largest tributary by volume—at Cairo, Illinois, that the river takes on the full grandeur that led Algonquian-speaking inhabitants to name it *Misi-zibi*—"Great River."

▷ FALSE MAP TURTLE

The endemic false map turtle is an inhabitant of large streams and rivers of the Mississippi-Missouri. It is often found basking on logs and rocks.



SHIFTING DELTAS

The modern Mississippi Delta evolved after the last ice age, when water levels began to stabilize. Over the last 9,000 years, it has shifted across a distance of about 200 miles (320 km), in a sequence of at least seven episodes. The seven major delta lobes and changing river courses are shown here.

